DMC notes on 1984

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Notes in Preface

Lens: Human Outlier Analysis (Foucault – "Madness and Civilization")

Our first story, *Notes from the Underground* by Fyodor Dostoevsky, takes place at a time I am pegging as the start of the "modern age." The story was first published in Russian in 1864 and takes place in Petersburg around 1862-1864, as the American Civil War is raging and as people in Russia are losing faith in traditional institutions, particularly Tsarist government, and are struggling with whether and how to absorb the lessons of the Western Enlightenment.

The unnamed protagonist of the story, often referred to as Dostoevsky's Underground Man, is in many ways an antihero. He defies rationalism and scientism and their concomitant notions of what is considered sane and acceptable. Many of us today might see the Underground Man as crazy in his verbose rambling and perverse actions. He may seem preposterous and confused, but do we lose something important if he is ostracized as a mental defective?

If we try to understand the Underground Man, perhaps we can better understand our fellow citizens today who seem to want to roll back to a time before Enlightenment values. Perhaps we can learn to recognize that they have important insights, even as we may view them as crazy.

One tool we will introduce could be called human outlier analysis[1].

We will ask questions about the Underground Man that could well be asked of ourselves and those around us:

- *How is the protagonist unusual in the society in which they live, and how are they trying to influence that society?*
- *Do you sympathize with the protagonist and his plight? What about the other characters?*
- *Can we usefully separate out the dysfunction from the creative insight?*
- *What does the protagonist see about society that those around him do not see?*

[1] On human outlier analysis, see:

- *Madness and Civilization* by Michel Foucault, 1961.

  This posits that a phenomenon of the Age of Reason is the attempt to eliminate the irrational from philosophical discourse. Institutions (such as hospitals and prisons) were developed to outcast radical thinkers as mad or criminal.